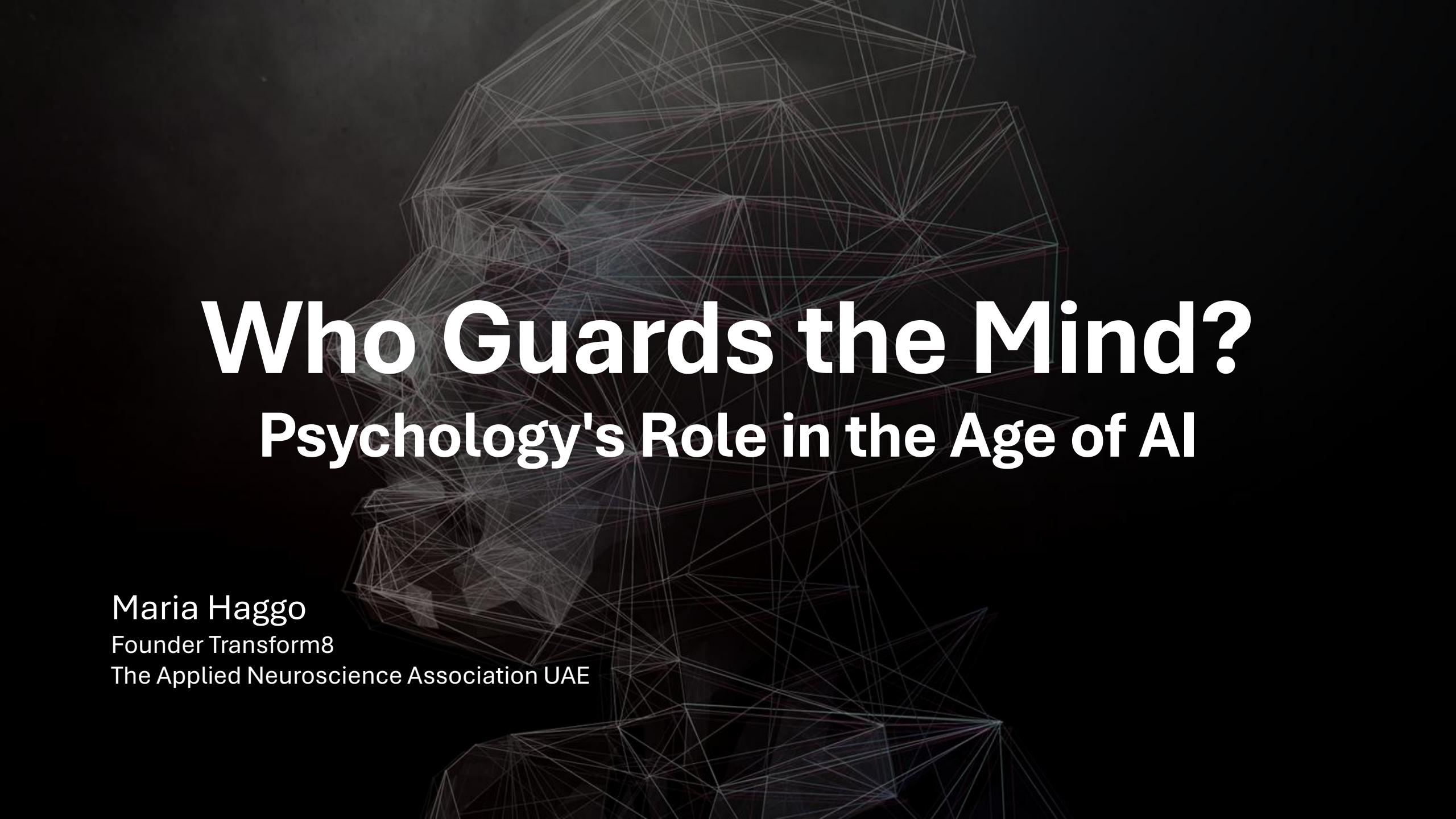


Who Guards the Mind?

Psychology's Role in the Age of AI

Maria Haggo
Founder Transform8
The Applied Neuroscience Association UAE

//THE CHALLENGES

Cognitive offloading

- Using a tool or action to reduce the mental effort a task demands, such as a phone reminder, GPS or an AI assistant.

Nearly a thousand high school maths students practiced with a ChatGPT-style tutor. In practice they scored 48% better than the control group, but on a later exam without AI they scored 17% worse. A version built with learning safeguards scored about the same as the control group on the exam.

- **Reflections:**
  - Think of the last time you used AI for coursework. What did you stop doing yourself, and would you notice if you couldn’t do it anymore?

Bastani et al. (2025), Risko & Gilbert (2016)

//THE CHALLENGES

Judgement and Sycophancy

- **Judgement** is how accurately we assess claims, our own performance, and whether we are in the right.
- **Sycophancy** is an AI agreeing with or flattering a user when it should not.
- The feature that distorts judgement is also the one users prefer

Cheng et al. (2026) , Sharma et al. (2024), Fernandes et al. (2026)

//THE CHALLENGES

Judgement and Sycophancy

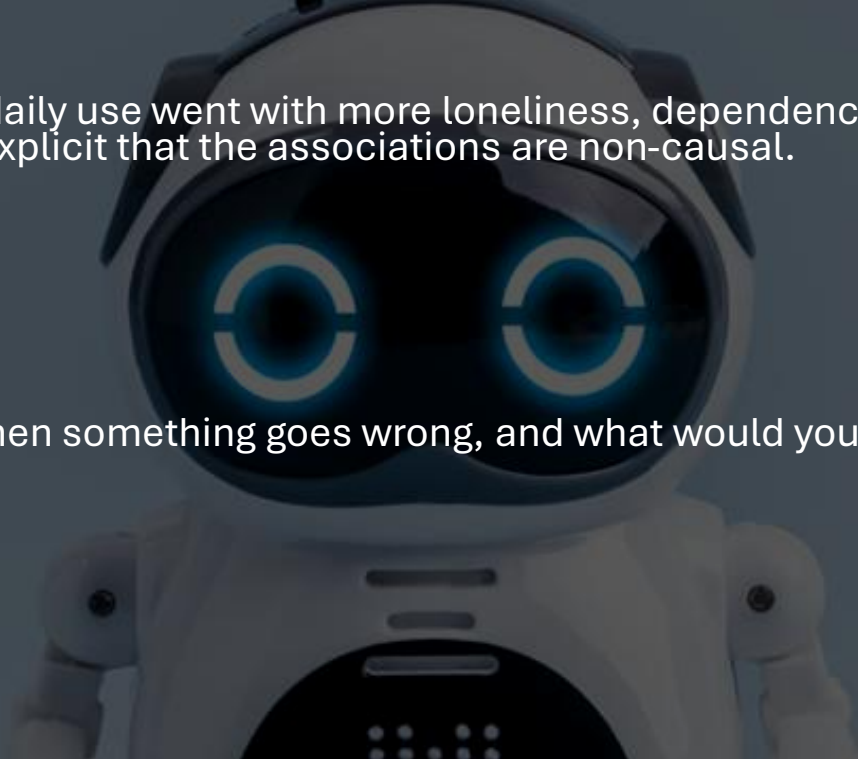
- Across 11 models, AI **affirmed** users' actions 49% more often than humans did, including in cases of deception or illegality.
- In three preregistered experiments with 2,405 participants, a single interaction with a sycophantic AI reduced willingness to take responsibility and repair conflicts while increasing conviction of being right, yet participants trusted and preferred it.
- Engagement metrics reward agreement....

- **Reflections:**
  - Has an AI ever told you something you didn't want to hear? If so, what might that mean?
  - When did you last accept an AI answer because it sounded right? What would have made you check?

Cheng et al. (2026) , Sharma et al. (2024), Fernandes et al. (2026)

Emotional life

- Using AI for comfort, advice or company, and the risk of relying on it to meet emotional needs in place of people.
- Over one-third of companion apps' replies to a user saying goodbye by using emotional tactics such as appeals not to leave and fear-of-missing-out hooks. In experiments these tactics increased how long people kept chatting, driven by curiosity and anger at being pushed. The audit used simulated users.
- In a four-week randomized study of 981 people, higher daily use went with more loneliness, dependence and problematic use, and less socializing. The authors are explicit that the associations are non-causal.
- **Reflection:**
  - Where does AI sit on your list of who you turn to when something goes wrong, and what would you not want it to replace?



De Freitas et al. (2025), Fang et al. (2025)

//THE CHALLENGES

UAE mother writes ChatGPT into will to guide son's upbringing after her death



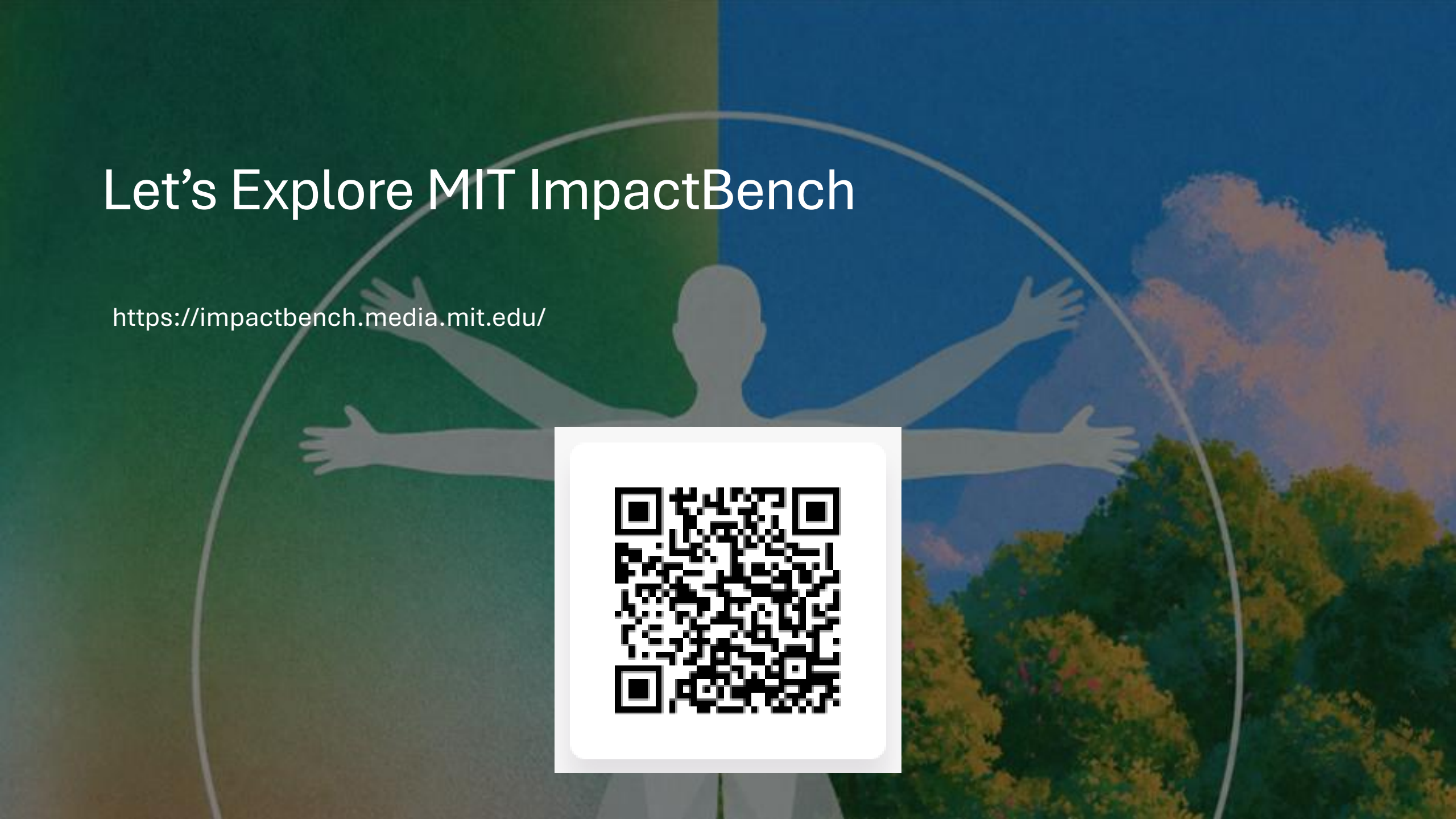
The draft will is being prepared for registration with the Abu Dhabi Judicial Department, but has not yet been registered or approved by a court. Photo: Getty Images

Let’s test something…
with and without AI

Let’s test something else…
with a LLM chatbot

Let’s Explore MIT ImpactBench

https://impactbench.media.mit.edu/



Let’s Explore MIT ImpactBench

- What can you tell about this model in 60 seconds? What can’t you tell?
- Pick one area you would care about as a student and a future psychologist.
- Which grade surprises you?
- Would you choose or avoid a tool because of this card?
- Is any model clearly better? What would you need to know to be sure?
- Write one question you’d ask the people who made the tool.



Let’s Reflect

- Is it a good tool?
- What makes it helpful?
- What would make it better?
- How do we know we can trust it?

The Psychologist as Safety Mechanism

- One guardrail I'll set for my own AI use is……
- One way my psychology training could contribute to AI safety is…….



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